engagements like the Brazil–Russia–India–China–South Africa (BRICS). Nonetheless, it seems that Modi has imparted new momentum to these efforts. His government has furthermore overcome the hesitations of history with the United States by inviting then-President Obama as chief guest to Republic Day celebrations and signing onto a joint vision of the Indo-Pacific and to the maintenance of the US-led rules-based order. The Modi government is also building closer links with Japan and showing less reserve or apology in forging the Quadrilateral Initiative with the United States, Japan, and Australia.

Third, the increasing importance of the Indian Ocean Region as part of the larger Indo-Pacific theatre adds to India's strategic significance and drives its maritime ambitions. With increased trade between Asia and Europe and China, Japan, and South Korea sourcing a large part of their crude oil from the Middle East, the Indian Ocean Region is one of the most important sea lanes in the world. Moreover, with China now turning to the sea and gradually projecting military capabilities into the Indian Ocean Region and the Indo-Pacific emerging as one strategic theatre, India's maritime and naval policies carry greater weight.[8] India's response to this development is shaped by its traditional perception of the Indian Ocean as its backyard and lack of enthusiasm for the presence of the navies of external powers, be it the superpowers during the Cold War or the increased presence of the Chinese Navy today.

This brings us to a fourth significant change shaping India's role in Asian security: the growing power gap vis-à-vis China. Although the Chinese threat is not new for India, China's rapid ascent during the last two decades represents a different type of challenge. In fact, in the same period as India has gained economic and military muscles itself, enabling it to adopt a more ambitious foreign policy, China's continued economic rise after the global financial crisis has taken the "Middle Kingdom" to another level. For instance, while China's GDP and military expenditure in 2005 were